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ALL THE WORLD IS A STOCK MARKET

THE MOVE to a new neighbourhood also meant a change of club. From Shadab Sports, I now joined Total Energy. Here the well-known former cricketer Aftab Ahmad was very supportive, as were the others, like Achay bhai, Bokhari sahib and Salahuddin Sallu – all local legends. By that time, I was playing regularly in the U-16 and U-19 tournaments, and was doing pretty well on the Karachi cricket circuit.

I was still coming in to bat at number seven or eight and getting 50s and 60s here and there, but it was my bowling that was really beginning to take off. I was scooping five- and six-wicket hauls in almost every game. An outcome of this was that observers, coaches and the local scouts didn't think much of my batting. They always thought I was a bowler and so did I. This would become a recurring reason for both belief and doubt in equal measure about my cricketing speciality, in the years that followed. I had no idea what lay ahead for me.

Eventually, the consistency with the ball paid off. I took my first step towards the big leagues when my name came up in the list of U-19 probables for an international tour to the West Indies. Haroon Rasheed was a selector at the time and the dynamic Mohammad Wasim was the captain. On a blazing hot afternoon in Karachi, I was called for a trial. I passed. I wasn't nervous or edgy. In fact, I was raring to go, ready and eager to be on my first foreign cricket tour. Moreover, this would be the first time I'd leave Pakistani soil and set foot in another country.

I want to share something here that I have never disclosed before. It's something that's very personal and will help you understand my thought process and approach towards cricket a lot better. It's a story about my roots, my fears and my focus.

My father, a reasonably successful entrepreneur by then had, thanks to someone's advice, invested a lot of money in the stock market. However, one day, when the markets crashed, as they always do, he lost a huge amount – around 10 million rupees (equivalent to around a hundred thousand dollars today, and around a quarter of a million dollars then) in a single day.

I still remember the day it happened. At the time we had a new house in Gulshan. We had a